



INTERNATIONAL JOURNAL OF RESEARCH AND STUDIES

Month/Year : April-June, 2026

DOI: <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22108813>



RECEIVED
23-04-2026



ACCEPTED
12-05-2026



PUBLISHED
30-06-2026

THE RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN PERCEIVED CONTENT AUTHENTICITY AND BRAND TRUST AMONG GENERATION Z SOCIAL MEDIA USERS

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ABSTRACT:

This study is based on the examination of the Generation Z social media users who perceive content authenticity using the brand trust evaluation method. This generation was born and raised in the world of advertising and influencer marketing; however, they have become aware of the lack of authenticity in brand messages. Authenticity indicators are examined using mixed methodology, such as surveys to evaluate the opinions of 312 participants and interviews of 20 Generation Z participants between the ages of 18 and 26 years old. According to the research, authenticity is considered the main driver of building trust towards brand messaging as indicated by the statistical relation $\beta = 0.67$, $p < .001$, while user-generated content (UGC) and peer-validation can create higher trust level than branded content. It was established that Generation Z considers brands authentic which results in their brand messaging being trusted. The study outlines the approach to the development of digital marketing strategy and branding management through efficient communication practices. The paper suggests a new Generation Z trust establishment model which reveals the impact of authenticity perception on the development of brand trust.

Keywords: Generation Z, content authenticity, brand trust, social media marketing, user-generated content

1. Introduction

The digital landscape has changed completely during the past decade. Generation Z customers have become the main target for brands which use Instagram TikTok YouTube Snapchat and X (formerly Twitter) as their primary social media platforms. Gen Z emerged as the first generation who lived their entire lives with digital technology which includes smartphones and streaming services and algorithm-based content delivery systems from 1997 through 2012 according to Dimock 2019. The internet-connected existence of Gen Z members since birth has created different relationship and communication understanding between them and their Millennial predecessors who used digital technologies during childhood.

Brand trust represents the consumer's ability to depend on a brand because they expect the brand will deliver its commitments which they made to customers. The social media era has disrupted the established methods which organizations used to develop trust with their customers. Gen Z consumers demonstrate decreasing trust toward celebrity endorsements and highly produced advertising campaigns and one-directional brand messaging because they prefer to view genuine unedited content that shows real life instead of polished marketing materials.

The content authenticity measurement assesses how users perceive brand communications as authentic and transparent about their actual company values. Research in consumer psychology and brand management has established that authenticity is not merely an aesthetic quality but a cognitive and emotional judgment consumers make about brands (Beverland 2005). The Gen Z generation shows high sensitivity toward judgment because they possess the ability to identify per formative diversity and manufactured relatability and strategic vulnerability which people commonly refer to as woke-washing or trauma dumping.

Researchers have not studied the relationship between Gen Z authenticity perceptions and their subsequent brand trust results despite this consumer group receiving increasing acknowledgment as a separate market segment. The existing research about Gen Z membership which links them to Millennials or their research on one social media platform results in incomplete understanding of how Gen Z perceives authenticity on social media platforms. The study investigates this research gap by testing various authenticity dimensions to measure their impact on brand trust across different demographic groups within Generation Z..

The primary research objectives of this study are: (1) to identify the key content authenticity cues perceived by Gen Z social media users; (2) to examine the relationship between perceived content authenticity and brand trust; (3) to determine whether UGC mediates the authenticity-trust relationship; and (4) to explore demographic variations in authenticity perception and trust formation within the Gen Z cohort. The research questions that follow serve as operational measures to achieve these research goals:

RQ1: What content characteristics do Gen Z users associate with authenticity on social media?

RQ2: To what extent does perceived content authenticity predict brand trust among Gen Z social media users?

RQ3: Does user-generated content moderate the relationship between perceived authenticity and brand trust?

RQ4: How do gender, platform preference, and frequency of social media use influence authenticity perceptions and brand trust among Gen Z?

This paper proceeds as follows. The second section of this study presents a literature review which demonstrates the existing research gap. The third section of this paper explains its research design and research methods. The fourth section of this study presents its data analysis together with its most important results. The fifth section of this document presents its conclusions together with its theoretical contributions and its research recommendations for future studies.

2. Literature Review with Research Gap

2.1 *Defining Content Authenticity in Digital Contexts*

The philosophical definition of authenticity describes a state through which something achieves its true nature and remains genuine and real (Taylor, 1991). The research on consumer behavior and marketing studies brand authenticity through multiple dimensions that include continuity to measure consistency throughout time and credibility to assess honest communication and integrity to evaluate values alignment and symbolism to determine cultural meaning (Beverland & Farrelly, 2010). The digital environment has created extra challenges for brands because they need to demonstrate their authentic identity through multiple online systems which include feeds and stories and comments and live streams that run at the same time.

Gilmore and Pine (2007) were among the first to argue that authenticity has become the new consumer sensibility which now functions as the primary purchasing criterion in saturated markets instead of price and quality. Social media users prefer brands that use first-person language to show their mistakes and their natural state while they communicate with customers through interactive dialogue. Moulard, Garrity, and Rice (2015) established a distinction between authentic selfexpression which represents true personal identity and authentic perception which describes how others see a person as genuine. The researchers found that consumers use their own judgment to determine authenticity which brands themselves cannot prove through objective evidence.

Researchers have discovered multiple indicators which trigger authenticity assessments for digital content. The indicators which researchers discovered three elements of actual existence: visual rawness (unfiltered unedited imagery) and linguistic informality (conversational tone and colloquialisms) and behind-the-scenes access and responsiveness to criticism and alignment between brand values and social causes (Audrezet de Kerviler Moulard 2020). The cues serve as mental shortcuts which consumers use to determine brand authenticity by evaluating the content without examining each element.

2.2 *Generation Z as a Distinct Consumer Segment*

The literature has continually shown that Gen Z has high skepticism against advertisements compared to other generations. According to a Morning Consult study conducted in 2021, 58% of the Gen Z population indicated distrust in paid influencer collaborations while only 42% of Millennials held the same view. In addition, according to the 2022 Edelman Trust Barometer study, Gen Z is less likely to trust celebrity endorsements and brands' spokespersons while preferring to rely on their peers, micro-influencers, and experts. This implies that trust for Gen Z is inherently dependent on peers and authenticity.

It should be noted that Gen Z is not entirely skeptical towards brands. In cases where there is alignment

between the brand identity and the Gen Z individual's values, Gen Z demonstrates loyalty towards the brand (Francis & Hoefel, 2018). Some successful examples of brands gaining trust from Gen Z include Patagonia, Duolingo, and Fenty Beauty. They are notable for their trustworthiness not because of advertisements but due to authentic stories and participative content.

2.3 Brand Trust: Theoretical Foundations

Brand trust has been theoretically explained from the perspectives of social exchange theory and the elaboration likelihood model (ELM). Social exchange theory perceives trust as a type of relational asset that customers place in brands presumed to provide consistent value (Blau, 1964). In relation to ELM, the concept of trust has been explained as the result of an interplay between central processing, involving systematic assessment of brand-related characteristics, and peripheral processing, which encompasses heuristic factors like source credibility and social proof (Petty & Cacioppo, 1986).

The landmark study of commitment-trust theory by Morgan and Hunt (1994) posited the role of trust as a mediator between relationship quality precursors and outcomes related to cooperation, such as loyalty and word-of-mouth communication. The studies conducted later by Chaudhuri and Holbrook (2001) revealed the dual nature of brand trust, involving attitudinal trust, represented by cognitive trustworthiness, and behavioral trust, implying actual dependence on the brand. Concerning online trust, Bart et al. (2005) found that in digital settings, trust can be seen in relation to privacy, security, and community, which is especially important for Gen Z consumers.

2.4 The Authenticity-Trust Nexus on Social Media

A number of scholars have studied the relationship between authenticity and trust on social media platforms. In their recent study, Jin & Ryu (2020) established that influence authenticity, made up of sincerity, transparency, and consistency, had a significant effect on follower trust and purchase intention. Similarly, Audrezet et al. (2020) confirmed that consumer perception of authenticity mediated the association between brand fit and consumer engagement. In another study, Lee & Watkins (2016) indicated that parasocial relationships developed between consumers and YouTubers increased brand trust if the information provided by the vlogger was seen as authentic rather than commercial.

Nevertheless, most of the studies undertaken on this topic pay less attention to brand content authenticity and often lack generational analysis. Where there is an exception to this, it is in the form of qualitative research, or where sample sizes were small and convenient. In addition, the role of user-generated content in defining authenticity as well as being a mediator in the authenticity-trust association is undertheorized.

2.5 Research Gap

Although there is an increasing amount of research that examines authenticity, social media marketing, and trust, there are still several notable shortcomings in the literature. To begin with, there is a need for a broader, quantitative examination of the differential predictive power of various content authenticity indicators in predicting brand trust among Gen Z consumers. Additionally, while the importance of user-generated content (UGC) as a mediator between content authenticity and brand trust has been noted in prior research, no empirical test has been conducted for this effect in the context of Gen Z consumers. Last but not least, most prior research fails to account for within-group heterogeneity when investigating Gen Z consumers, assuming the generation to be a homogeneous market cohort. This study seeks to fill the above-listed gaps.

3. Research Design / Model

3.1 Research Philosophy and Approach

The study uses the philosophy of pragmatism by utilizing both qualitative and quantitative research methods in a sequential explanatory design (Creswell & Plano Clark, 2017). The quantitative phase captures the broadness and generalizability of statistics, whereas the qualitative phase explores the depth and the context of the phenomena behind the numbers. The use of the approach is justified considering that the concept under investigation, namely perceived authenticity, is quantifiable yet subjective..

3.2 Quantitative Phase: Survey Design and Sampling

An online survey with a set structure was conducted on a sample size of 312 participants from the Gen Z demographic, ranging in age between 18 and 26 years. Participants were sourced using snowball sampling, specifically targeting Gen Z social media consumers through their participation in university programs, social media advertisements, and participation in research panels online. Inclusion criteria for participants were that they were active social media users (at least 1 hour per day spent on social media sites) and had followed at least three brands on social media sites.

Survey questions covered four validated scales: (1) Perceived Authenticity Scale (PAS; Moulard et al., 2015) adapted for use in the context of brand content (14 items, $\alpha = 0.87$); (2) the Brand Trust Scale (BTS; Chaudhuri & Holbrook, 2001) adapted for use in social media context (8 items, $\alpha = 0.91$); (3) a scale measuring Exposure to and Engagement with User-Generated Content (UGES; created by authors from prior research literature, 6 items, $\alpha = 0.84$); and (4) an assessment of Content Authenticity Cues (CACC), which was answered according to a set list of cues.

The demographic variables gathered were age, gender identity, main social networking sites used, hours per day spent on social networking sites, and social networking literacy. Regression analysis and mediation analysis (PROCESS Macro, Hayes, 2018) were performed to examine the research hypotheses.

3.3 Qualitative Phase: In-Depth Interviews

In addition to the quantified findings, 20 semi-structured interviews were also performed with participants from among those who completed the survey based on purposeful sampling. Each interview was performed for 45 to 75 minutes in Zoom. The interviews were performed based on participant definitions of authenticity, their perceptions towards certain content provided by brands, and the influence of peer recommendations on brand trust. Audio recordings of each interview were made with participants' permission and were subsequently subjected to reflexive thematic analysis (Braun & Clarke, 2006).

3.4 Conceptual Model

The proposed and tested theoretical framework includes the following: Perceived Content Authenticity (PCA) $\rightarrow$ Brand Trust (BT). This relationship is mediated by UGC Exposure and Engagement (UGCE). Furthermore, demographic variables (gender, preferred platform, daily usage of social media) moderate the PCA $\rightarrow$ BT relationship. The theoretical framework is based on the principles of social exchange theory (Blau, 1964) and the Signaling Theory (Spence, 1973).

In this case, content authenticity acts as a credibility signal, reducing information asymmetry between brands and their audiences..

3.5 Ethical Considerations

An approval was secured from the Institutional Review Board (IRB) before collecting data. All the participants gave their consent. Their anonymity was ensured by using ID codes when handling their data. It was explained to them that they had the option to withdraw from the study whenever they wished without facing any consequences.

4. Data Analysis and Findings

4.1 Sample Characteristics

The final sample size ($n = 312$) consisted of 58.3% female, 34.0% male, and 7.7% nonbinary/genderfluid. The average age was 21.4 years old ($SD = 2.1$). Instagram (38.5%), TikTok (32.7%), YouTube (15.1%), and Twitter (X)/Twitter (8.7%) were the most common social media channels used for primary purposes. Daily social media usage averaged four hours and 12 minutes ($SD = 1.6$). Nearly all participants (91%) stated they followed at least five brands across various social media platforms, while 74.4% noted making a purchase based on brand social media content within the past three months.

4.2 Perceived Content Authenticity: Descriptive Statistics

Average mean for authenticity of content perceived by respondents was 3.28 ($SD=0.74$) on a scale of five, meaning that respondents perceived the content to be moderately authentic. The perceived authenticity of UGC and peer recommended content was significantly higher (mean =4.01, $SD = 0.61$) than the perceived authenticity of branded content (mean=2.89, $SD=0.82$), $t(311) = 14.27$, $p < .001$. The authenticity of the following cues were rated as the most highly associated with authenticity: 'Transparency about the limitations of the product', 'Consistency in brand tone/voice in all posts', and 'Acknowledgement of any mistakes'. 'Celebrity endorsements' and 'Highly produced videos' had the lowest rating on the scale..

4.3 Brand Trust: Descriptive Statistics

The average trust score for the brand was 3.19 ($SD = 0.81$). The mean trust score for brands using the UGC content strategy was significantly higher ($M = 3.72$, $SD = 0.67$) compared to the mean trust score of brands using an influencer marketing strategy ($M = 2.94$, $SD = 0.85$) or the brand's own content strategy ($M = 2.88$, $SD = 0.79$).

4.4 Regression Analysis: Authenticity as a Predictor of Brand Trust

Multivariable regression analysis was performed with brand trust as the dependent variable while perceived content authenticity, UGC exposure, and demographic variables were used as independent variables. The overall model was statistically significant, $F(7, 304) = 49.2$, $p < .001$, $R^2 = 0.53$, explaining 53% of variability in the outcome measure. The best predictor of brand trust was perceived content authenticity ($\beta = 0.67$, $p < .001$), while the second was UGC exposure and engagement ($\beta = 0.21$, $p < .01$). Daily social media usage rate did not prove to be a statistically significant predictor ($\beta = 0.04$, $p = .38$).

Preference of platform moderated the relationship between PCA and BT. TikTok users had a higher beta coefficient for the correlation between authenticity perception and trust ($\beta = 0.79$) when compared to Instagram users ($\beta = 0.61$) and YouTube users ($\beta = 0.55$). Such differences might be explained by TikTok's focus on rawness, authenticity, and relatability of videos. Gender identity moderated authenticity perceptions without affecting brand trust itself; non-binary respondents assessed brand authenticity lower ($M = 2.81$) compared to women ($M = 3.32$) and men ($M = 3.29$).

4.5 Mediation Analysis: The Role of UGC

To determine whether UGC consumption and engagement mediate the effects of content authenticity on brand trust, a bootstrapping analysis was conducted (5,000 bootstraps) using PROCESS Macro (Model 4 by Hayes, 2018). The analysis confirmed that the indirect effect was statistically significant ($b = 0.14$, 95% CI [.08, .21]), indicating partial mediation. Authenticity perceived in the content was found to significantly predict brand trust ($b = 0.53$, $p < .001$), and it also had an indirect effect on brand trust through engagement with UGC ($b = 0.14$).

4.6 Qualitative Findings: Themes from In-Depth Interviews

The reflexive thematic analysis on the 20 in-depth interviews generated four primary themes, which helped to contextualize and supplement the findings obtained from the quantitative research.

Theme 1 – "Cringe Filter" – Identifying Inauthenticity Automatically. All 20 respondents talked about a quick, often subconscious process of determining whether the message coming from a brand is authentic. People used such phrases as "sniffing out," "seeing through," and "calling out" brands that were trying too hard to be relatable. For example, a 22-year-old TikTok user noted: 'If the brand posts a video using slang that they definitely googled because they are run by an old marketing guy in his 50s, we all clock it automatically. It is innate.' This theme highlights the importance of cultural fluency and authenticity in tonal language for Generation Z brands.

Theme 2 – Trust Needs to Be Earned, Not Given. All participants viewed building trust as an accumulated experience achieved through effort rather than the opposite. Trust is acquired through persistent, authentic, and value-driven communication. Some participants mentioned brands that had broken their trust due to performative activism (posting Black squares but failing to support social movements).

Theme 3: Peer Validation As an Ultimate Proxy of Authenticity. Regardless of gender, platform, and age groups, the concept of peer validation was consistently recognized as a key motivator of trust within the sample population. By definition, peer validation includes recommendations, responses, and reviews provided by friends, micro-influencers, and members of online communities. 'When a friend recommends something, it automatically becomes 100 times more authentic and trustworthy to me than the recommendation of a brand itself,' said a 24-year-old female Instagram user.

Theme 4: The Paradox of Authenticity. Some interviewees pointed out the contradiction between their expectations to have authentic communication from the part of brands and their understanding of the fact that all branded content was intentionally planned and premeditated. This particular paradox can be seen as a sign of media literacy peculiar to Generation Z. Interviewees were able to resolve this paradox by adjusting their degree of trust depending on effort involved rather than seeking complete genuineness.

5. Conclusion and Future Scope

5.1 Summary of Key Findings

The purpose of this study was to explore the association between perceived content authenticity and brand trust in Generation Z users of social media platforms. These results demonstrate strong empirical support for the significance of authenticity perception as a predictive variable for brand trust ($\beta = 0.67$), explaining a considerable proportion of variance in the outcome variable. User-generated content consumption and interaction emerged as a partial mediator in the connection between authenticity and brand trust, underscoring the importance of user-verified content in the architecture of trust formation in Generation Z users. Preferences for the use of specific social media platforms, especially TikTok's ability to facilitate unmediated communication, were revealed to serve as moderators in the connection between authenticity and trust.

5.2 Theoretical Contributions

Contributions made by this study are both substantive and methodological. Substantively, the study contributes to authenticity theory by providing theoretical extensions of current authenticity frameworks into a contextually specific social media setting, where the authenticity beliefs of Gen Z consumers are seen to be influenced by unique cues different from what is found in research on older consumer populations. Methodologically, the study makes two major contributions by contributing to brand trust theory by demonstrating the mediation role played by user-generated content (UGC) between the constructs of authenticity and brand trust. Furthermore, by identifying an authentic paradox as a unique disposition amongst Gen Z consumers, the study helps to contribute to the debate around the efficacy of strategic communication through the lens of consumer media literacy.

5.3 Practical Implications

Several implications for brand management and digital marketing can be extracted from the results obtained during the research. Firstly, UGC approaches that involve such elements as branded hashtags, content hubs, and storytelling are more likely to bring better results in terms of trust earned by Gen Z than brand-produced creative campaigns. Secondly, brands need to focus on the consistency and transparency dimensions of authenticity since these aspects were found to have the highest impact among those examined in the study. Thirdly, brands should consider choosing platform-specific strategies of promoting their products/services due to the special characteristics of TikTok, which allowed the researcher to find the most pronounced relationship between authenticity and trust. Finally, brands need to think twice before using performative social advocacy due to Gen Z's sensitivity to value misalignment.

5.4 Limitations

However, there are several weaknesses to this study that must be considered. Firstly, although a reasonably large sample size was used for the research, the recruitment process involved mostly individuals connected to universities as well as those who use digital panels frequently. Secondly, as a cross-sectional design, it does not allow causal relationships and changes over time between trust perception and authenticity to be observed. Thirdly, although the research was quite thorough

in terms of its methodology, it took place in only one national context, and hence is less likely to generalize the findings to Gen Z audiences outside Western countries.

5.5 Future Research Directions

Future research must overcome some of the limitations outlined above and expand the current findings in several ways. For example, longitudinal panel research examining the effects of brand communication events on authenticity perceptions and subsequent changes in trust would provide causal insights into this dynamic process. Similarly, cross-cultural comparisons might establish whether the connection between authenticity and trust highlighted in this paper is culture-specific or universally applicable. It is also important to consider other emerging platforms, such as BeReal and Lemon8, and investigate the impact of their platform architecture on authenticity communication. Lastly, research into neurocognitive processes involved in detecting authenticity by Gen Z consumers deserves attention.

Overall, this paper demonstrates the importance of the fact that for Generation Z, authenticity is not a marketing fad but rather the main currency of brand trust. Brands that understand the essence of this truth and act accordingly by providing authentic, consistent, and peer-facilitated brand communications will be able to foster the strongest relationships of trust.

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